Unimaginably and ironically, thirty years later, I was combating terrorists in the same area as a brigade commander.

Barely in our teens, what interested us then were our studies and games. In the absence of a vibrant media in those days, we were neither aware of the political undercurrents nor very concerned with them. These aspects have been discussed in more detail in Part III of this book.

Our parents did not send us to any boarding school, perhaps because they couldn't afford it. My father was the only commissioned officer in the entire family, and had the responsibility of bringing up not only his children but many others too. Besides, my parents believed that children could be given greater personal care, and also taught family traditions and spiritual values better, at home.

My parents have had the greatest influence on me as a child, my late mother in particular. Rani Jaspal Kaur was a wonderful person and an excellent homemaker. She brought up a large family very efficiently and lovingly. I was her first-born, and perhaps because of that, she had a special attachment to me. A pious lady, she sacrificed everything for her family. Though frail in health towards the end, she lived to see her son become the army chief, and died peacefully in her sleep in February 2005, a fortnight after that event. She was cremated in a befitting and dignified ceremony at the Brar Square in Delhi Cantonment. This was the same place where my grandfather's last rites were conducted with appropriate military honours.

My father is ninety-one, and by the grace of God, in good health. He is caring and devoted to his very large family of six children, thirteen grandchildren and fifteen great-grandchildren! At one point in time before his retirement, he was a proud father having three sons serving in the defence forces. My elder brother, Squadron Leader S.J.S. 'Satti' Marwah, was an ace fighter pilot and acclaimed flying instructor in the Indian Air Force; I was serving in the Maratha Light Infantry; and the third, Captain B.J. Singh, was an exceptionally gifted and talented doctor in the Army Medical Corps. Satti served as an instructor in Iraq's Air Force Academy at Tikrit for